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NAVRATRI 2026

The Complete Home Guide

Nine Days · Nine Colours · Nine Devis

Sharadiya Navratri · **11 - 19 October 2026** · Vijayadashami (Dussehra) **20 October 2026**

Ghatasthapana vidhi · Navadurga profiles · day-wise colours · vrat food plan · Kanya Pujan · budget planner · printable trackers

Welcome — Read This Page First

Navratri is nine nights, nine forms of the Goddess, and — in most homes — a scramble through ten different websites to find the dates, the colours, the muhurat and the fasting rules. This guide puts all of it in one place, in the order you will actually need it, and in plain English.

How to use this guide

- **Before Day 1:** read Chapter 1 (the 2026 calendar) and Chapter 2 (Ghatasthapana), then gather your samagri using the checklist in Chapter 12.
- **Each morning:** follow the 10-step home puja in Chapter 4, and check the day's Devi, colour and bhog from the master table in Chapter 1.
- **If you are fasting:** use the vrat food plan and 9-day menu in Chapter 5, and read the health-first note before you begin.
- **On Ashtami / Navami:** use the Kanya Pujan vidhi in Chapter 6.
- **Planning ahead:** the budget planner (Chapter 8) and the printable trackers (Chapter 12) are designed to be filled in and kept on the fridge.

Please read — how to use the timings in this guide. All muhurat windows here are given for **New Delhi** as a planning reference, with a few other cities noted. Tithi start and end times shift with your city's sunrise, so confirm the Ghatasthapana, Sandhi Puja and Parana windows on your local panchang or with your family priest before you begin. The nine-colour chart is a popular modern custom that varies by region — treat it as a joyful tradition, not a rule. Anyone who is pregnant, unwell, elderly or managing a condition such as diabetes should follow a doctor's advice rather than a strict fast.

What is inside

1. Navratri 2026 at a Glance — dates, the 2026 quirk, the master nine-day table
2. Ghatasthapana — muhurat, samagri and step-by-step vidhi
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Facts in this guide were checked in early October 2026 against published 2026 panchang calendars (drikpanchang.com and panchang references), the Economic Times and Hindu festival calendars, and standard Navadurga devotional material. A source list is on the last page.

1. Navratri 2026 at a Glance

Navratri means "nine nights". It is the worship of Goddess Durga in her nine forms — the *Navadurga* — observed in the bright fortnight of the lunar month of Ashwin (Ashwin Shukla Paksha). Of the two Navratris in a year, the autumn one, **Sharadiya (or Sharad) Navratri**, is the larger and the one most families across India observe. It opens with **Ghatasthapana** and closes with **Vijayadashami**, also called Dussehra — the day Durga's victory over the buffalo-demon Mahishasura is celebrated.

The key dates for 2026

Event	Date (2026)	Reference note
Pratipada tithi begins	Sat, 10 October	From about 9:19 PM
Navratri Day 1 & Ghatasthapana	Sun, 11 October	Forenoon, while Pratipada runs
Navratri Days 2-7	Mon 12 - Sat 17 October	One Devi form each day
Day 8 (Saptami repeats)	Sun, 18 October	Colour: purple
Durga Ashtami + Sandhi Puja + Maha Navami	Mon, 19 October	All three together this year
Navami tithi ends	Tue, 20 October	About 12:50 PM
Navratri Parana & Vijayadashami (Dussehra)	Tue, 20 October	After the Navami tithi ends
Durga Visarjan	Tue, 20 October	Idols immersed

The 2026 quirk — why the last days compress

Navratri follows lunar tithis, not fixed 24-hour days, and in 2026 the tithis bunch up at the end. **Saptami** is present at sunrise on both 17 and 18 October, so those two civil days carry the same tithi label. Then **Ashtami and Navami merge onto Monday 19 October** — Ashtami ends around 10:51 AM, and Navami takes over and runs until about 12:50 PM the next afternoon. The two anomalies cancel out, so Navratri still runs its full nine days, from 11 to 19 October, with **Dussehra on Tuesday 20 October**.

Because the Devi forms follow the tithi, the last two forms — **Mahagauri** (Ashtami) and **Siddhidatri** (Navami) — are honoured on the same day, Monday 19 October, alongside Durga Ashtami, the Sandhi Puja at the Ashtami-Navami junction, and Maha Navami. Many households still keep the eighth-day Mahagauri custom on Sunday 18 October. Follow your family's practice; there is no single universal answer for 18 October.

1b. The Nine Days at a Glance

Colours are the widely-published 2026 sequence for a Navratri that begins on a Sunday. The order changes every year because the first colour is set by the weekday Navratri begins on; the custom is strongest in Gujarat and Maharashtra and varies by family.

Day	Date (2026)	Tithi	Devi	Colour	Bhog / Naivedya
1	Sun, 11 Oct	Pratipada	Shailaputri	Orange	Pure cow's ghee
2	Mon, 12 Oct	Dwitiya	Brahmacharini	White	Sugar / mishri
3	Tue, 13 Oct	Tritiya	Chandraghanta	Red	Kheer (milk)
4	Wed, 14 Oct	Chaturthi	Kushmanda	Royal Blue	Malpua
5	Thu, 15 Oct	Panchami	Skandamata	Yellow	Banana
6	Fri, 16 Oct	Shashthi	Katyayani	Green	Honey
7	Sat, 17 Oct	Saptami	Kalaratri	Grey	Jaggery
8	Sun, 18 Oct	Saptami (repeats)	Mahagauri*	Purple	Coconut
9	Mon, 19 Oct	Ashtami → Navami	Siddhidatri	Peacock Green	Sesame; halwa-puri-chana for Kanya Pujan
—	Tue, 20 Oct	Dashami	—	—	Vijayadashami / Dussehra & Parana

*On 18 October, panchangs differ: some continue Saptami worship, some repeat Kalaratri, some place Mahagauri there. No panchang treats 18 October as Ashtami. Purple is the colour listed for that day in every 2026 sequence.

Two rhythms to remember. The *tithi* decides which Devi is worshipped; the *weekday* decides the colour. That is why you can print one table and still be right on the day — just check your local panchang for the exact tithi window each morning.

2. Ghatasthapana — Starting Navratri Right

Ghatasthapana (also called Kalash Sthapana) is the ritual that opens Navratri. A *kalash* — a metal pot filled with water — is installed and invoked as the seat of the Goddess, and barley seeds (*jau*) are sown in soil in a small pot to grow the *jawara* (the sacred sprout). The jawara that grows over the nine days is a living symbol of the nine nights and is offered on the final day.

Ghatasthapana muhurat — Sunday, 11 October 2026

Window	Time (reference)	City
Ghatasthapana muhurat	06:19 – 10:12 AM	New Delhi
Abhijit muhurat (alternative)	11:44 AM – 12:31 PM	New Delhi
Abhijit muhurat	12:01 – 12:48 PM	Mumbai
Ghatasthapana / Abhijit	06:26 – 10:17 AM / 11:50 AM – 12:36 PM	Ujjain

2026 caveat. On the morning of 11 October, **Chitra nakshatra** and **Vaidhriti yoga** both span the main window — and both are traditionally avoided for kalash sthapana. Because of this, many panchangs recommend the **Abhijit muhurat around local noon** this year as the safer choice. The practical rule stays simple: complete the sthapana in the forenoon while Pratipada is running, and take your family priest's or local panchang's word on the exact minute.

What you will need (samagri)

- A *kalash* — copper, brass or silver pot
- Clean water (some families add Ganga jal)
- 5 or 7 mango leaves and a coconut (with its husk)
- Red cloth and sacred thread (*mauli/kalawa*)
- Barley seeds (*jau*) and clean soil for the jawara
- A small earthen or metal pot for sowing
- Durva grass, flowers and red hibiscus if available
- Ghee lamp (*akhand jyoti* if your family keeps one)
- Incense, camphor, kumkum, turmeric, sandalwood
- Rice, a coin or two, and some fruit for naivedya
- A clean chowki (low platform) and a Durga image or idol
- A bell, and a thali for the aarti

Ghatasthapana vidhi — step by step

1. **Clean and prepare.** Bathe and wear clean clothes. Clean the puja space and place a fresh red cloth on the chowki.
2. **Set the kalash.** Fill the kalash with clean water. Place mango leaves around its mouth, then seat the coconut on top. Tie the sacred thread around the neck of the kalash.
3. **Sow the jawara.** Put clean soil in the small pot, scatter the barley seeds, and cover lightly with more soil. Water gently. Keep it near the kalash.
4. **Install Durga.** Place the image or idol of the Goddess on the chowki, with the kalash beside it.
5. **Light and offer.** Light the ghee lamp and incense. Offer flowers, durva grass, kumkum, turmeric and the day's naivedya (ghee on Day 1).
6. **Invoke and pray.** Chant the Devi mantras in Chapter 4 — begin with ॐ देवी शैलपुत्र्यै नमः — and pray for the household.
7. **Do the aarti.** Perform the aarti with the thali and bell.
8. **Water daily.** Water the jawara each morning, keep the lamp lit where your family keeps an *akhand jyoti*, and offer fresh flowers and bhog every day for nine days.

What to avoid. Do not let the jawara dry out, and do not sow it after the forenoon window. Keep the puja space undisturbed; where a family keeps an *akhand jyoti*, the lamp should not go out. Traditionally, non-vegetarian food and alcohol are kept away from the house during the nine nights.

3. Meet the Nine Devis

Each night of Navratri honours a different form of Durga, together called the **Navadurga**. The nine forms rise in a deliberate order — from the daughter of the mountain to the giver of perfection. Read one profile each morning, and you will know exactly who you are praying to and why.

1. Shailaputri **Day 1 · 11 Oct · Orange**

Shailaputri means "daughter of the mountain" — born to the Himalaya. She is worshipped at the very start, as the foundation of the nine nights. She rides a bull and holds a trident and a lotus.

What she blesses: a firm, grounded beginning; courage to start. **Bhog:** pure ghee. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी शैलपुत्री नमः (Om Devi Shailaputryai Namah).

2. Brahmacharini **Day 2 · 12 Oct · White**

Brahmacharini is the ascetic form — the Goddess in tapasya, holding a rosary and a kamandalu, walking barefoot. She is the form of devotion, discipline and penance. **What she blesses:** self-control, patience and the strength to keep a fast or a vow. **Bhog:** sugar or mishri. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी ब्रह्मचारिण्यै नमः (Om Devi Brahmacharinyai Namah).

3. Chandraghanta **Day 3 · 13 Oct · Red**

Chandraghanta wears the half-moon shaped like a bell on her forehead. Ten-armed, riding a tigress, she is the warrior form who sounds the bell of war against evil. **What she blesses:** courage, protection and freedom from fear. **Bhog:** milk or kheer. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी चन्द्रघण्टायै नमः (Om Devi Chandraghantayai Namah).

4. Kushmanda **Day 4 · 14 Oct · Royal Blue**

Kushmanda is said to have created the universe with a gentle smile — "the cosmic egg". She glows like the sun and lives in the heart of the sun. **What she blesses:** health, energy and light; the removal of darkness. **Bhog:** malpua. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी कूष्माण्डायै नमः (Om Devi Kushmandayai Namah).

5. Skandamata Day 5 · 15 Oct · Yellow

Skandamata is the mother of Skanda (Kartikeya). She holds her child on her lap and rides a lion — the tender mother and the fierce protector in one form. **What she blesses:** the wellbeing of children, and the bond of mother and child. **Bhog:** banana. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी स्कन्दमातायै नमः (Om Devi Skandamatayai Namah).

6. Katyayani Day 6 · 16 Oct · Green

Katyayani was born in the sage Katyayana's home and is the warrior who slew Mahishasura. She rides a lion and carries a sword. **What she blesses:** victory in difficult battles and the courage to face what frightens you. **Bhog:** honey. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी कात्यायन्यै नमः (Om Devi Katyayanyai Namah).

7. Kalaratri Day 7 · 17 Oct · Grey

Kalaratri is the fiercest form — dark as the night, with wild hair and a garland of lightning, riding a donkey. She destroys fear, negativity and evil, yet is called the most auspicious for her devotees. **What she blesses:** the destruction of fear and of all that troubles the mind. **Bhog:** jaggery. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी कालरात्र्यै नमः (Om Devi Kalaratryai Namah).

8. Mahagauri Day 8 · 18 Oct · Purple

Mahagauri is luminous and calm — the Goddess after her tapasya, radiant as the moon, dressed in white, riding a bull. She is peace and purity after the storm. **What she blesses:** calm, peace and the washing away of old burdens. **Bhog:** coconut. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी महागौर्यै नमः (Om Devi Mahagauryai Namah).

9. Siddhidatri Day 9 · 19 Oct · Peacock Green

Siddhidatri is the giver of *siddhis* — spiritual attainments and perfection. She sits on a lotus, worshipped by gods and sages alike. **What she blesses:** fulfilment, wisdom and the completion of what you began. **Bhog:** sesame; and halwa, puri and kala chana for Kanya Pujan. **Mantra:** ॐ देवी सिद्धिदात्र्यै नमः (Om Devi Siddhidatryai Namah).

4. Daily Puja Vidhi & Mantras

You do not need a priest to keep Navratri well at home. A short, sincere routine repeated for nine days is worth more than an elaborate one you abandon on day three. Here is a 10-step morning puja you can do in fifteen minutes.

The 10-step home puja

1. **Bathe and clean.** Take a bath and wear clean clothes before you begin.
2. **Light the lamp.** Light the ghee lamp and incense in front of the Goddess and the kalash.
3. **Offer water.** Offer clean water to the idol or image, then to the kalash.
4. **Offer flowers.** Offer fresh flowers, durva grass and red hibiscus if you have them.
5. **Apply tilak.** Offer kumkum, turmeric and sandalwood to the Goddess.
6. **Chant the day's mantra.** Recite the day's bija mantra (Chapter 1b), then the common Devi mantras below.
7. **Offer bhog.** Offer the day's naivedya — ghee, sugar, kheer, malpua and so on, per the table.
8. **Do the aarti.** Perform the aarti with the thali and bell; the whole family can join.
9. **Receive prasad.** Distribute the prasad.
10. **Water the jawara.** Water the barley sprout gently, and keep the lamp lit if your family keeps an akhand jyoti.

Common Devi mantras

Navarna (the nine-syllable) mantra:

ॐ ऐं ह्रीं क्लीं चामुण्डायै विच्चे

Om Aim Hreem Kleem Chamundaye Vichche

For universal welfare:

सर्वमंगलमांगल्ये शिवे सर्वार्थसाधिके। शरण्ये त्र्यम्बके गौरी नारायणि नमोऽस्तुते॥

Sarva Mangala Mangalye, Shive Sarvartha Sadhike, Sharanye Tryambake Gauri, Narayani Namostute.

The Devi present in all beings:

या देवी सर्वभूतेषु शक्तिरूपेण संस्थिता। नमस्तस्यै नमस्तस्यै नमस्तस्यै नमो नमः॥

Ya Devi Sarva Bhuteshu Shakti Rupena Samsthita, Namastasyai Namastasyai Namastasyai Namo Namah.

Durga Saptashati. Many families read the *Durga Saptashati* (also called the *Devi Mahatmya*) — 700 verses in 13 chapters describing Durga's battles with Mahishasura and other demons — across the nine days, or on Ashtami and Navami. You can read a chapter a day, or listen to a recitation. A complete, correctly translated text is available in any standard Durga Saptashati book or from your temple; recite from a trusted printed edition rather than a screenshot.

5. The Vrat Food Plan

A Navratri *vrat* is a **sattvik fast**: for most families it means giving up regular grains (wheat, rice), pulses, onion and garlic, and eating light, pure foods instead. You do not have to eat nothing — you eat differently. The aim is discipline and lightness, not starvation.

The rules in one glance

Eat during the vrat

- Sabudana (sago) — khichdi, tikki, kheer
- Kuttu (buckwheat) and singhara (water-chestnut) flour
- Rajgira (amaranth) and sama / samak rice
- Makhana (fox nuts), peanuts, cashew, almond
- Potato, sweet potato, arbi, pumpkin, tomato, cucumber
- Milk, curd, paneer, ghee
- Fruit, coconut, and rock salt (*sendha namak*)

Keep away during the vrat

- Wheat, rice, and all regular grain flours
- All dals, rajma, chana (except for Kanya Puja day)
- Onion, garlic, and heavy masalas
- Non-vegetarian food, eggs and alcohol
- Common iodised salt — use *sendha namak*
- Fried and packaged snacks where you can avoid them

Health first — this matters more than the fast. A strict nine-day vrat is not for everyone. If you are **pregnant or nursing, diabetic, unwell, elderly, or on medication**, speak to a doctor before you begin and follow their advice. A partial vrat — one meal of vrat food a day, or fasting only on Ashtami and Navami — is completely acceptable and is what many families actually do. Keep water and fluids up through the day; a fast should never make you dizzy or unwell.

A simple nine-day vrat menu

A ready plan for anyone fasting who does not want to decide every day. Swap freely — the point is vrat-friendly food, cooked fresh, and not too heavy.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
1	Fruit bowl + milk	Sabudana khichdi + curd	Kuttu roti + aloo sabzi
2	Banana + makhana	Samak rice + paneer curry	Singhara roti + lauki
3	Vrat poha + curd	Rajgira roti + arbi	Sabudana kheer + fruit
4	Milk + soaked almonds	Kuttu puri + aloo	Paneer tikka + salad
5	Fruit + coconut water	Samak khichdi + curd	Rajgira paratha + tomato chutney
6	Sabudana tikki + curd	Makhana curry + sama rice	Paneer bhurji + singhara roti
7	Banana milkshake	Kuttu khichdi + curd	Aloo-jeera + rajgira roti
8	Makhana + fruit	Paneer + samak rice	Light sabudana khichdi
9	Fruit	Kanya Pujan bhoj — halwa, puri, kala chana	Light khichdi + curd

Vrat shopping list (tick as you buy)

- ☐ Sabudana (sago) — 1 kg
- ☐ Kuttu atta — 1 kg
- ☐ Singhara atta — 1 kg
- ☐ Rajgira atta — 1 kg
- ☐ Samak / sama rice — 1 kg
- ☐ Makhana — 500 g
- ☐ Sendha namak (rock salt)
- ☐ Peanuts, cashew, almond
- ☐ Potato, arbi, sweet potato, tomato
- ☐ Milk, curd, paneer, ghee
- ☐ Fruit and fresh coconut
- ☐ Sugar / mishri, jaggery, honey

6. Kanya Puja (Kanjak)

Kanya Puja — also called Kanjak or Kanjaka — is the worship of young girls as living forms of the Goddess. It is usually held on **Ashtami or Navami**. In 2026 both fall on **Monday, 19 October**, so many families will keep Kanya Puja that day; some keep it on Sunday 18 October with their own Ashtami custom. Traditionally nine girls are invited (the number can range from two to nine), representing the nine forms of Durga.

The vidhi

1. **Invite the girls.** Invite young girls — traditionally aged around 2 to 10 — to your home for the puja and a meal.
2. **Welcome them.** Wash or sprinkle water on their feet, and welcome them with respect as the Goddess herself.
3. **Apply tilak.** Apply kumkum and a little sandalwood on their foreheads.
4. **Tie the kalawa.** Tie the sacred thread (mauli) on their wrists.
5. **Offer flowers.** Offer them flowers, and pray to each as one of the nine Devis.
6. **Serve the bhoj.** Serve the traditional meal — **halwa, puri and kala chana** (sookhi kala chana) — with water and a sweet.
7. **Give dakshina.** Offer dakshina — money, a small gift, fruit or a new item of clothing — to each girl.
8. **Seek blessings.** Touch their feet or bow in respect, and take their blessings before they leave.

On the food and the dakshina. Halwa, puri and kala chana is the standard Kanjak bhoj, though some families add fruit and a glass of water. On this day kala chana is allowed even in fasting households. There is no fixed amount for dakshina — a note of ₹51, ₹101 or more per girl, or a small gift, is entirely a matter of what your family does. The spirit is respect, not expense.

What to avoid

- Do not treat it as a formality — the girls are honoured as the Goddess, so be genuinely respectful.
- Do not serve leftover or ordinary non-vrat food on the puja day if your family is fasting.
- Do not skip the dakshina or the farewell blessings — they are part of the ritual, not an optional extra.

7. Colours, Decor & Outfits

Wearing the day's colour is a modern, much-loved Navratri tradition — strongest in Gujarat and Maharashtra, where the day's shade runs from office wear to garba outfits. The colour chart is a joyful custom rather than a scriptural rule, and it is rebuilt every year from the weekday Navratri begins on. Here is the 2026 sequence and a quick meaning for each.

Day & Date	Colour	What it stands for	Simple styling idea
1 · Sun 11 Oct	Orange	Warmth, energy, new beginnings	Orange kurta or dupatta with gold jewellery
2 · Mon 12 Oct	White	Purity, peace, calm	White chikankari or cotton set with silver
3 · Tue 13 Oct	Red	Power, passion, devotion	Red saree or anarkali — the classic Navratri red
4 · Wed 14 Oct	Royal Blue	Depth, richness, divine energy	Royal-blue kurta with a contrast dupatta
5 · Thu 15 Oct	Yellow	Joy, brightness, optimism	Yellow cotton suit — bright and festive
6 · Fri 16 Oct	Green	Growth, nature, new life	Green kurta or lehenga with oxidised jewellery
7 · Sat 17 Oct	Grey	Balance, strength, restraint	Grey kurti with a bright dupatta to lift it
8 · Sun 18 Oct	Purple	Ambition, spirituality, royalty	Purple saree or dress with gold accents
9 · Mon 19 Oct	Peacock Green	Individuality, freshness, compassion	Peacock-green or teal outfit for the finale

Decor on a budget

- **Diya corner:** a row of clay diyas along a window or the puja area — the cheapest and most effective Navratri look.
- **Toran and flowers:** a marigold toran at the door, or a garland of marigold and durva on the puja chowki.
- **Rangoli:** a simple floral or geometric rangoli at the entrance, refreshed each day with the day's colour.
- **Drape a dupatta:** a bright dupatta or fabric behind the puja area instantly frames the Devi.
- **Reuse, don't rebuy:** rotate the same diyas, fabric and flower strings in the day's colour rather than buying new decor each night.

The simplest rule: pick **one** strong colour a day — on your outfit, in a rangoli, or in the flowers — and let the rest stay neutral. It looks intentional, costs little, and honours the colour tradition without a shopping trip.

8. Navratri on a Budget

Navratri can be as expensive or as simple as you decide. The bands below are planning guides for a typical Indian household — adjust them to your city and family size. Fill in the blank column with your own numbers before Day 1.

Head	Lean	Standard	Grand	Your plan
Puja samagri (kalash, coconut, seeds, lamp, flowers)	₹400	₹900	₹1,800	_____
Jawara soil, pot and barley seeds	₹40	₹80	₹150	_____
Vrat groceries (9 days, per family)	₹1,500	₹2,600	₹4,000	_____
Flowers, diyas and decor	₹300	₹800	₹2,500	_____
Kanya Pujan bhoj + dakshina (9 girls)	₹900	₹1,800	₹3,000	_____
New outfit for the colours (optional)	₹0 (reuse)	₹1,500	₹5,000	_____
Garba / dandiya / event passes (optional)	₹0	₹1,000	₹3,000	_____
Approximate total	₹3,150	₹8,700	₹19,500	_____

Four ways to keep Navratri affordable

- **Buy samagri in one trip.** One list, one market visit — the last-minute purchases are always the costly ones.
- **Shop the vrat staples in bulk.** Sabudana, kuttu and singhara atta keep well; buying a little extra before Navratri is cheaper than buying small packets each day.
- **Reuse decor every year.** A good set of diyas, a toran and a couple of dupattas last for years. Rotate them rather than rebuying.
- **Set the Kanya Pujan budget in advance.** Decide the dakshina per girl before you invite, so the gesture stays joyful and not stressful.

These bands are indicative planning figures for 2026, not quotes. Prices vary widely by city and brand — your local market will be the real guide.

9. Regional Celebrations

Navratri is one festival with many faces. The nine nights look different in every region, and knowing the local flavour helps whether you are travelling or joining a celebration.

Gujarat — Garba & Dandiya Raas

Gujarat celebrates Navratri as nine nights of dancing. Families and neighbourhoods gather for **Garba** (a circular dance around a lamp or image of the Goddess) and **Dandiya Raas** (played with decorated sticks). People dress in the day's colour, and the nights run late. It is the most visible public form of Navratri in India.

Maharashtra — Ghatasthapana & Bhondla

Maharashtra keeps the kalash with devotion and celebrates with the **Bhondla** (or Hadga) gathering, where girls and women sing traditional songs in a circle. The ninth day, **Navami**, is also observed as a day to worship the implements of one's work.

Bengal — Durga Puja

In West Bengal, the autumn festival becomes **Durga Puja**, the biggest celebration of the year. Elaborate *pandals* house grand idols, and the days run from **Shashthi through Vijaya Dashami**, culminating in **Vijaya Dashami on 20 October 2026** — with *Sindoor Khela* and the immersion of the idols. It is as much a cultural festival as a religious one.

South India — Golu / Bommai Kolu

In Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra and Kerala, homes set up the **Golu** (Bomma Kolu) — tiered displays of dolls and figurines of gods, saints and everyday life. Families and neighbours visit each other's Golu, and offerings such as *sundal* (a lentil dish) and coconut are shared. In Karnataka the festival is called **Dasara** and the tenth day is celebrated with great pomp.

North India & Punjab

Across North India and Punjab, the emphasis is on fasting, daily Devi puja, and **Kanjak** on Ashtami or Navami. In Punjab, the festival is often called **Navratre**, and the Kanya Puja meal of halwa, puri and chana is the central family ritual. Dussehra is celebrated with Ramlila and the burning of Ravana's effigy.

10. Plan Navratri with AI — 8 Copy-Paste Prompts

Use any AI assistant (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude) to cut the planning time. Paste a prompt, then edit the answer to fit your family. Always check religious details against your panchang or priest — treat AI as a helper, not an authority.

1. **Nine-day menu:** "Create a 9-day Navratri vrat menu for a family of 4 in India, using only sabudana, kuttu, singhara, rajgira, samak rice, makhana, paneer, potato and fruit. Give breakfast, lunch and dinner for each day, and a combined grocery list with quantities."
2. **Budget planner:** "Build a Navratri 2026 household budget for a family of 4 in [city] with a total cap of ₹[amount]. Break it into puja samagri, vrat groceries, flowers and decor, Kanya Pujan and optional garba passes. Suggest where to save."
3. **Decor ideas:** "Give me 10 low-cost Navratri home decor ideas using diyas, marigold, dupattas and rangoli, that I can set up in under 30 minutes a day, for a small apartment."
4. **Colour-outfit match:** "For the 2026 Navratri colour sequence Orange, White, Red, Royal Blue, Yellow, Green, Grey, Purple, Peacock Green, suggest one outfit from my existing wardrobe of [list clothes] for each day, keeping it simple and office-appropriate."
5. **Kanya Pujan plan:** "Make a Kanya Pujan checklist for 9 girls at home on 19 October 2026 — invitation message, bhoj menu with quantities for halwa, puri and kala chana, seating, dakshina ideas and a thank-you message for parents."
6. **Invitation messages:** "Write 5 short, warm WhatsApp invitations for a Navratri garba evening at home, in English and Hindi, under 40 words each."
7. **Kids' activity:** "Suggest 7 Navratri activities for children aged 5–10 at home — colouring, story, simple craft and a kid-friendly retelling of the Navadurga — that take under 20 minutes each."
8. **Vrat for a health condition:** "I am [condition, e.g. pre-diabetic] and want to keep a lighter Navratri vrat. Suggest vrat-friendly meals that are low in sugar and high in protein, and flag anything I should ask my doctor about." *(Then actually ask your doctor.)*

The golden rule with AI and festivals: let it help you plan menus, budgets, decor and messages — but verify every date, tithi, muhurat and mantra against a trusted panchang, priest or printed text before you act on it. AI can be confidently wrong about religious detail.

11. Dos, Don'ts & Common Mistakes

Most Navratri mistakes are small and easy to avoid. Here are the twelve that trip up households most often.

#	The mistake	Do this instead
1	Sowing the jawara after the forenoon window	Complete Ghatasthapana on Day 1 morning while Pratipada runs
2	Letting the jawara or the akhand jyoti go dry or out	Water the jawara and check the lamp every morning
3	Following last year's colour chart	Use the 2026 sequence — it changes with the weekday each year
4	Assuming the Devi for 18 October is fixed	Accept that family practice differs this year; follow yours
5	Fasting so strictly you feel unwell	Keep a partial vrat, and follow a doctor's advice if unwell
6	Using ordinary iodised salt in vrat food	Use sendha namak (rock salt)
7	Forgetting Kanya Pujan falls on 19 October this year	Mark 18–19 October and plan the bhoj early
8	Serving non-vrat food on the Kanya Pujan day	Serve halwa, puri and kala chana as the traditional bhoj
9	Treating Kanjak as a formality or skipping dakshina	Honour the girls as the Goddess, with respect and a gift
10	Copying muhurat times from another city	Confirm the window on your own city's panchang
11	Reading the Durga Saptashati from a random screenshot	Recite from a trusted printed edition or your temple's text
12	Spending beyond your means to "do it properly"	Set a budget with Chapter 8 and keep the celebration simple

The one thing to get right. Navratri is a festival of devotion and discipline, not of perfection. If you keep the lamp, water the jawara, offer what you can, and fast within what is healthy for you, you have observed it well. Everything else — the exact minute, the perfect colour, the elaborate decor — is a bonus.

12. Trackers & Checklists

Nine-day tracker — print and fill in

Day / Date	Devi	Colour	Puja done	Vrat	Bhog offered	Notes
1 · Sun 11 Oct	Shailaputri	Orange	☐	☐	☐	
2 · Mon 12 Oct	Brahmacharini	White	☐	☐	☐	
3 · Tue 13 Oct	Chandraghanta	Red	☐	☐	☐	
4 · Wed 14 Oct	Kushmanda	Royal Blue	☐	☐	☐	
5 · Thu 15 Oct	Skandamata	Yellow	☐	☐	☐	
6 · Fri 16 Oct	Katyayani	Green	☐	☐	☐	
7 · Sat 17 Oct	Kalaratri	Grey	☐	☐	☐	
8 · Sun 18 Oct	Mahagauri	Purple	☐	☐	☐	
9 · Mon 19 Oct	Siddhidatri	Peacock Green	☐	☐	☐	Kanya Puja ☐

Ghatasthapana checklist

- ☐ Clean puja space, fresh red cloth
- ☐ Kalash filled, mango leaves, coconut
- ☐ Barley seeds sown, soil watered
- ☐ Durga image/idol placed
- ☐ Lamp, incense, flowers ready
- ☐ Muhurat confirmed for your city

Kanya Puja checklist

- ☐ Girls invited (aim for up to 9)
- ☐ Halwa, puri, kala chana planned
- ☐ Dakshina and small gifts ready
- ☐ Kumkum, mauli, flowers kept out
- ☐ Seating and water arranged
- ☐ Thank-you message for parents

Daily essentials checklist

- ☐ Water the jawara ☐ Check the lamp ☐ Fresh flowers ☐ Day's bhog ☐ Aarti ☐ Day's colour worn

Navratri 2026 — Quick Answers

The ten questions households ask most, answered in one place.

Question	Answer
When is Navratri in 2026?	Sharadiya Navratri runs from Sunday 11 October to Monday 19 October 2026 , with Vijayadashami (Dussehra) on Tuesday 20 October .
When should I do Ghatasthapana?	On Day 1, Sunday 11 October , in the forenoon while the Pratipada tithi runs. In New Delhi the main window is 06:19–10:12 AM, with the Abhijit muhurat (11:44 AM–12:31 PM) often preferred this year.
Which colour on which day?	2026 sequence: Orange (11 Oct), White (12), Red (13), Royal Blue (14), Yellow (15), Green (16), Grey (17), Purple (18) and Peacock Green (19 Oct).
Why do Ashtami and Navami fall on the same day this year?	Because the lunar tithis compress at the end of Navratri 2026. Ashtami ends around 10:51 AM on 19 October and Navami then runs until about 12:50 PM the next day, so Durga Ashtami, Sandhi Puja and Maha Navami are all kept on 19 October.
Do I have to fast for all nine days?	No. A partial vrat — vrat food once a day, or fasting only on Ashtami and Navami — is perfectly acceptable and common. Anyone pregnant, unwell, elderly or managing a condition should follow a doctor's advice.
When is Kanya Puja this year?	Usually on Ashtami or Navami — in 2026 both fall on Monday 19 October . Some families keep their Ashtami custom on Sunday 18 October.
Can I observe Navratri without a kalash?	Yes. If you cannot do a full Ghatasthapana, a clean puja space with a lamp, flowers and the Devi mantras is a sincere and complete observance at home.
What is the jawara?	Barley seeds sown in soil on Day 1 that sprout into a green shoot over the nine nights — a living symbol of Navratri, offered on the final day.
Which mantras should I chant?	The day's bija mantra (Chapter 1b), the Navarna mantra, and common Devi mantras such as Sarva Mangala Mangalye and Ya Devi Sarva Bhuteshu (Chapter 4).
Are the muhurat times the same in my city?	No. Tithi timings shift with your city's sunrise. The windows in this guide are for New Delhi as a reference — always confirm on your own local panchang or with your priest.

Sources & Notes

Every date, tithi, colour, muhurat window and ritual detail in this guide was compiled and cross-checked in early October 2026. Where sources differed — as they do for the 18 October Devi and for city-wise timings — the difference is flagged in the text and the reader is pointed to their local panchang.

Dates, tithis and muhurat

- Drik Panchang — Navratri 2026 nine colours and nine-day calendar (drikpanchang.com)
- PanchangBodh — Sharad Navratri 2026 dates, tithi compression and Abhijit muhurat
- HinduLab — Sharad Navratri 2026 nine-day calendar, Ghatasthapana and Sandhi Puja windows
- The Economic Times (Astrology) — Navratri 2026 dates, Ghatasthapana muhurat, nine colours and Navdurga schedule
- Divine Hindu — Navratri 2026 day-wise table, bija mantras and city muhurat (Delhi, Mumbai, Ujjain, Varanasi)

Navadurga forms, mantras and rituals

- Standard Navadurga devotional material — nine forms, bija mantras, bhog and significance
- Traditional Devi mantras — the Navarna mantra, Sarva Mangala Mangalye and Ya Devi Sarva Bhuteshu
- Durga Saptashati (Devi Mahatmya) — described here, not reproduced; recite from a trusted printed edition

Important notes

- Muhurat windows are given for New Delhi as a planning reference; tithi timings shift with your city's sunrise. Confirm on your local panchang before performing the rituals.
- The nine-colour chart is a modern, regional custom mapped to the weekday; it changes every year and varies by family and region.
- Fasting guidance is general. Anyone pregnant, unwell, elderly or managing a medical condition should follow a doctor's advice, not a strict vrat.

The Navratri 2026 Complete Home Guide

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May the nine nights bring you strength, peace and everything you have prayed for. Jai Mata Di.